

A PRINTABLE SCOUTING TRIP COMPANION

The Scouting Trip *Workbook*

Print this and take it with you. The framework from **Visit Before You Decide**, structured as a worksheet you can fill in as you go and refer back to when the decision is in front of you.

Pre-trip checklist fills in at home. Daily logs fill in each evening on the road. The after-the-trip section gets completed at least 48 hours after you return, not before.

YOUR TRIP

City

Travel dates

Trip length

Season tested

From **RetireMeHere** · Real data, honest tradeoffs · retiremehere.com

SECTION 01

Before You Go

Complete the pre-trip checklist at least a week before you fly. The more you do here, the less you have to scramble for once you arrive.

☐ **Trip dates locked, four days minimum.**

Five or six is ideal.

☐ **Visiting in the hardest season for you, not the prettiest.**

Florida in September. Phoenix in July. Boston in February.

☐ **Two or three candidate neighborhoods identified.**

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

☐ **Trip priced three ways: warehouse-club, package site, individual components.**

Costco, Sam's Club, or AAA first if you're a member, then Expedia or Travelocity, then individual on Booking.com.

☐ **Rental car reserved at the arrival airport.**

Unless the city is truly walkable (Charleston, St. Pete, Delray Beach).

☐ **Nearest major hospital identified.**

Hospital _____

☐ **At least one Medicare-accepting primary care doctor's phone number on hand.**

Call from the trip to confirm they're taking new patients.

Practice / phone _____

☐ **Cultural anchor identified (museum, garden, historic district).**

Anchor _____

☐ **Travel insurance priced if applicable.**

Worth a quote if visiting a hurricane zone, traveling June through November, or with pre-existing conditions.

☐ **The top two questions I want this trip to answer.**

1. _____
2. _____

SECTION 02

Daily Observation Logs

Fill in each evening, while the day is still fresh. The point is to capture honest reactions, not pretty notes. Scratch and cross out as you go.

DAY ONE

Arrive, settle, drive the neighborhoods at dusk

A travel day. Do not push for activity. The one thing you must do is the evening neighborhood drive.

ARRIVAL IMPRESSIONS

Airport (easy / okay / difficult)

Drive from airport to lodging (minutes)

First impressions from the car

EVENING DRIVE: CANDIDATE NEIGHBORHOODS

Neighborhood 1 name

Sidewalks, lighting, signs of life at this hour

Neighborhood 2 name

Sidewalks, lighting, signs of life at this hour

Neighborhood 3 name (if applicable)

Sidewalks, lighting, signs of life at this hour

END OF DAY REFLECTION

DAY TWO**Cultural anchor, local lunch, first reality check**

Test the city's self-image. Eat where residents eat. Time a hospital drive.

CULTURAL ANCHOR

Anchor visited

Hours spent

Did the city's self-image fit the retirement I want?

LONG LUNCH IN A RESIDENTIAL NEIGHBORHOOD

Restaurant / neighborhood

Did the neighborhood feel like a place I would spend time?

REALITY CHECK: HOSPITAL DRIVE

Drive time at 3 PM (minutes)

Estimated drive time at 7 AM (minutes)

Any concerns about the route or hospital

END OF DAY REFLECTION

DAY THREE

Neighborhood deep dive and the traffic test

Spend half the day in your favorite candidate neighborhood. Then run the rush-hour traffic test.

MORNING NEIGHBORHOOD WALK

Neighborhood walked

Grocery store visited

Pharmacy / coffee shop / community space

What's missing from the neighborhood

Could I do my daily errands here? Honestly?

REALITY CHECK: RUSH HOUR TRAFFIC

Route driven (from / to)

Time of day / total drive time

Frustration level 1-10 (10 = unacceptable)

Notes on the drive

END OF DAY REFLECTION

DAY FOUR

Healthcare, community, final walkaround, depart

The hardest reality checks happen today. The doctor call. The community visit. The final honest look.

HOSPITAL VISIT

Hospital visited / brochures collected

First impressions

REALITY CHECK: MEDICARE-ACCEPTING DOCTOR CALL

Doctor / practice called

Accepting new Medicare patients? (Y/N)

If yes, wait time for first appointment

If no, alternatives suggested

REALITY CHECK: COMMUNITY / FAITH / SOCIAL CLUB

Community visited

Welcoming? (Y/N) — and how I could tell

Did I see people I would want to spend time with?

FINAL NEIGHBORHOOD WALKAROUND

SECTION 03

After the Trip

Wait at least 48 hours after returning home before filling any of this out. No earlier. The scouting trip high needs to wear off before you can read your real reactions honestly.

THE "WHAT I DIDN'T LIKE" EXERCISE

Sit down with whoever you are making this decision with and answer one question only: **what did you not like about the city?** Not what you liked. Only the negatives. They will tell you more than the positives will.

Negative 1

Negative 2

Negative 3

Negative 4

Negative 5

DEALBREAKERS

Negatives I cannot live with

MANAGEABLE

Real but workable

SURPRISED ME

Did not see coming

WHERE THIS CITY STANDS NOW**The decision, after the dust settles****COMPARED TO WHAT I EXPECTED, THIS CITY IS:**

- ☐ Better than I expected
- ☐ About what I expected
- ☐ Worse than I expected

NEXT STEP:

- ☐ This is a strong candidate. Plan a housing-focused visit two.
- ☐ Scout a different city first, then compare.
- ☐ I am ready to make my decision.
- ☐ I am not ready and need more time.

THE TWO QUESTIONS THAT MATTER MOST

Am I deciding with my head or my heart, honestly?

What would I tell a friend about to make the same decision?

SECTION 04

Questions and Observations to Share

What surprised you on this trip? What do you wish you had known before you went? We learn from every scouting trip our readers take, and good questions teach us what to add to the next version of this workbook. If you have a moment, send what came up to us.

Questions I still have about this city or the process

Anything that surprised me or that I wish I had known beforehand

Send to: **hello@retiremehere.com** (or reply to the email that delivered this workbook). With your permission, we may anonymize and share recurring questions to help future scouting trips.

RETIREMEHERE

For the next city, print a fresh copy

The framework is the same for any city you scout. Print a new workbook for each trip and start at the beginning.

retiremehere.com/visit-before-you-decide